

Title: Why Is The Holy Trinity Not a Mystery: A Philosophical Perspective

"I believe in Trinity" or "I don't believe in Trinity" may be more understandable for someone who has read this article. From the early times, when the idea of trinity arose, to the present-day, when it is considered as the backbone of mainstream Christianity(Catholic, Oriental Orthodox, Eastern Orthodox, Lutherans, Anglicans Churches), it has often been described as a mysterious doctrine in which God/ YHWH/ is three in person and one essence. The three persons, as you likely already know, are the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit.

I will try to make the discussion less historical and more philosophical.

For someone who is already familiar with Old Testament, The synoptic gospels can be very convincing in presenting Jesus Christ as God, as YHWH. Since such a person also believes that God is one, he/she may feel compelled not to set any boundary that distinguishes them. Here, we must first be clear about what we mean by YHWH, since the development of the Jewish understanding of God is undeniably complex. However to remain consistent with the title of the article, I will proceed by treating YHWH as equivalent to the Christians understanding of God.

The term Trinity is coined from latin word *trinitas* by the early christian writers such as Tertullian to address the confusion arising from the Gospels and the Epistles. The term *trinitas* is etymologically derived from the Latin word *trinus*, meaning "threefold", which itself comes from *tres*, meaning "three". The *-itas* is a suffix similar to the English *-ity*, which indicates the quality or state of an abstract nouns. Therefore, when the word Trinity is used, it refers to the state or quality of being three. This leads to an important question, what exactly is "three" about the Trinity? To answer this question, I will briefly introduce the concept of substance in the philosophy of Aristotle.

In Aristotelian metaphysics, substance(Greek term *ousia*) is that which is neither predicable of a subject nor presented in a subject. Aristotle writes, "of things without qualification, some are said of subject, some are in subject, but some exist neither in a subject nor are said of a subject. These latter are substance." Here the term *Subject*(Greek term *hypokeimenon*) refers to the thing that exists independently. It holds the qualities and properties of the things we are speaking of. For example, consider a tree. The "tree" is a subject, it possesses properties such as color, length and other characteristics. This makes it a primary substance. Qualities are always within subject and dependent on it. They cannot exist outside the subject. When Aristotle says something is "said of subject," he means it cannot exist on its own. When he says something is "in a subject," he

refers the accidents or the properties that belong to the subject. In this sense, subjects are an ontologically prior to their qualities. Meanwhile, substance(ousia) is the ultimate reality, the *whatness* or *essence* of the thing we are speaking about. Aristotle distinguishes primary and secondary substance. He taught that the primary substance is the concrete individual entities as in "Abraham" and "Tree". It is ontologically first, meaning any changes or mutations depend on it. The secondary substance is the genus/species of the thing being mentioned. They represent essence. For example, when referring to Aristotle as a primary substance we are talking about his actual existence or simply Aristotle himself(the hypostasis). When referring to Aristotle as a secondary substance we are talking about his humanness.

"God is one in essence," says any monotheistic person. However, this statement can appear somewhat trivial, almost like saying "one car is one car," because even we humans share one essence, our whatness, the human nature. In principle, It would be possible to imagine hundreds or thousands of gods sharing the same essence. For this reason, it may be more precise to say the divine substance is one. This formulation helps resolve the confusion. When we say that there exists a single divine substance, we mean that only one divine entity exists, an entity possessing its own unique essence, which no other entities possess. If this is the case, how does the doctrine of Trinity teach that this one God exists as a three distinct persons? Truly, this part of my study was particularly interesting, because it is here that the broader picture of the Trinity begins to emerge.

Mainstream Christians believe God has three eternally existing properties that was, are and will always be with him. This properties are paternity, begottenness(filiation) and procession. As I explained earlier, these properties cannot exist outside of God, rather, they exist within God. One might ask how we are able to speak about them as distinct if they all exist within the same divine reality. This is explained through what is called a metaphysical distinction. In metaphysics, there are mainly two types of distinctions that can help explain this issue. Real distinction and formal distinction. A real distinction occurs when things are distinct in reality, that is, when they exist outside of one another. By contrast, formal distribution is when different aspects are truly present in the same thing, yet they are completely distinct in their aspect, even though they cannot exist separately. This is what is occurs in the doctrine of Trinity, the three properties of the single divine substance are formally distinguished and then hypostasized. Hypostasis is a Greek term commonly used in the explanatiin of the Holy Trinity. Hypostasis can be understood as giving a concrete expression to the distinct aspects that result from one of the two metaphysical distinction allowing us to speak of them as independent realities. The term is often use in place of "person," treating each distinct hypostasis as a single, self-subsiding

entity within the one divine substance. This means whatever we are doing distinguishing the three properties of the divine substance and hypostasizing them, it is entirely a formal distinction, nothing *real* going here.

Around the 5th century a Christian theologian Boethius attempted to discuss the simplicity of God using classical philosophy. Following him, Thomas Aquinas and others continued this effort. The idea they drew upon traces back to ancient Greek philosophy, especially Aristotle, who emphasized the simplicity of the first cause (the unmoved mover) when formulating his account of motion and change. Aristotle argued that anything occurring within a chain of continuity must have a first cause that initiates the process, and this first cause must be unchanging, simple, and eternal. Later, Christian philosophers applied Aristotle's idea to their own frameworks, giving rise to the principle of divine simplicity. This principle was then used to teach God is not made up of parts, rather He is fundamentally simple and indivisible.

So far, we have been treating God as a substance. According to the principle of divine simplicity, God is not composed of parts, unlike created substances. This principle affirms that, unlike humans, who are composed of systems, organs and blood, all of which are really distinct from the person, God's properties are identical to Himself. Therefore, whatever we attribute to God is God. Consequently, all the three properties of the divine substance are God (not Gods) because of the principle of identity implied by divine simplicity.

One of the greatest mistakes made by many who discuss the Holy Trinity is assuming that the distinction among the three persons (therefore the properties) are real and teaching as if the three properties exist independently outside God. There is no magic here, the three hypostatic distinctions of the God in the doctrine of Trinity are entirely formal distinctions, not separate substances. Moreover, the three properties that are hypostasized and called equally God, due to the principle of divine simplicity, they exist fully within God. If the distinction was truly real we would be speaking of three Gods, rather than one.

Therefore, I believe the Trinity is not a mystery, it's simply a matter of philosophical understanding.

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